

INTERNSHIP REPORT

A Comprehensive work report of knowledge & experiences gained during my internship in Child Rights and You (CRY)

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Intern – Summer Internship 2025 @ CRY

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My sincere thanks to the Community organizers **Ms. Karpagam, Ms. Chithra, Ms. Alamelu, Ms. Usha, Ms. Bharathi, Ms. Rani & Ms. Murugammal** for guiding me throughout the survey in rural parts. I would like to Thank the other interns **Ms. Saranya** and **Mr. Rahul**, for their efforts in serving the underprivileged.

Self-Introduction

I am a Native of Salem city, Tamil Nadu. I graduated from University of Madras, as a master in Geography. Currently, I am a Teach for India fellow, teaching 44 students of Low-income private Middle school in Avadi, Chennai. I am always fascinated about reaching out to the communities while being a teacher. I feel the best part of my work is to make connections with people. I work in an Urban setting, and I thought to connect with the Rural India and wanted to know the ground reality there, as Mahatma Gandhi once said “Villages are the backbone of our nation.” Since the academic year was over, I got to take a break from my teaching responsibilities during the summer break. I felt the need to engage myself in things that would give me a vast exposure. As a result of which I thought to explore different ways to engage with Village communities and found myself calling in the works of CRY, an organization that works for the Welfare of children in India. I thought to utilize my summer vacation both fruitfully & truthfully, and it moved me to apply for an intern role in CRY. I went through application scrutinization and a one & one interview with the manager and got selected to intern for a month.

Introduction – Child Rights & You

Child Rights and You (CRY) is a leading Indian non-governmental organization (NGO) that has been working towards ensuring the rights of underprivileged children since its inception in 1979. Founded by Rippan Kapur, CRY envisions a just society in which all children enjoy their rights to survival, protection, development, and participation. The organization partners with grassroots-level NGOs, communities, and government systems to create sustainable change in the lives of marginalized children across India.

CRY adopts a rights-based approach, focusing not only on the immediate needs of children but also addressing the root causes of deprivation through systemic change. Its work spans critical areas such as education, healthcare, nutrition, protection from child labour and abuse, and participation in decision-making processes. With a presence in multiple states across India, CRY has impacted the lives of millions of children and continues to advocate for policies and practices that uphold child rights.

Orientation – Day 1 of the internship

The internship duration officially started on 5th of May 2025, with a formal orientation session conducted online by the Staff team of CRY. All the interns were briefed with the Standard procedures of how the organization works, their milestones & achievements. We were also instructed the code of conduct and general expectations from interns during the call. We have also been appointed with mentors who will be guiding us with our roles & responsibilities.

Campaign for Fundraising

As a part of our internship program, we were asked to raise funds for the movement **#PooriPadhaiDeshKiBhalai**. CRY has helped 1.7 lakh girls enrol in school, but thousands more still need our support. When a girl is educated, she gains the power to break free from poverty, delay early marriage, and secure better opportunities for herself and her family. Educating girls doesn't just transform individual lives—it strengthens entire communities and the nation.

Appeal



Sriram Shankar



Hello all, My name is Sriram Venkatesh, and I'm currently interning with Child Rights and You (CRY). Today, I'm reaching out with an earnest appeal. Every girl deserves an education — but in India, many are still denied this basic right. Despite laws guaranteeing free education, girls often drop out due to poor school infrastructure, early marriage, and gender bias. One major barrier is the lack of separate toilets for girls, which makes school unsafe and uncomfortable, especially during menstruation. Only 3 out of 5 girls in India make it to higher secondary school. With your support, we can change this. Help us build safe, girl-friendly schools and give every girl the chance to learn, grow, and thrive. Donate now — invest in a girl's future.

Our target was to raise Rs. 5000/- during this period. My skills & experiences with fundraising in the previous years has helped me to contact the right donors in my close circle. I reached out to them with an earnest appeal to Help CRY build safe, girl-friendly schools and give every girl the chance to learn, grow, and thrive. I have achieved the target throughout the 4 weeks of my internship period.

I would like to thank CRY for giving me this opportunity to fundraise for a very great cause. I am grateful for the beautiful hearts that helped me to achieve this milestone in my life.

After the orientation, we were asked to create a Fundraiser link of our own, which will make it easy for us to reach out to our contacts for Funds. We were also given a handbook, A guide to fundraising that contained some tips and guidance on Fundraising skills. I began to search for potential donors in my contact list and made my own Fundraiser link. By the end of Week 1, I was able to collect.

Link for my fundraiser : https://www.ketto.org/supportfundraiser/hope-for-her-education-zmu1n?utm_medium=whatsappShare&utm_content=8567877&shby=1&utm_term=whatsappShare&utm_source=internal&utm_campaign=hope-for-her-education-zmu1n&payment=form

Introduction – Salem People Trust (SPT)

Since I was residing in Salem, I was asked to support the works of **SALEM PEOPLE TRUST (SPT)**, since CRY is a major funding partner of SPT. I knew SPT as a part of my Middle of the Year Retreat , from the organization I work, that we had during the month of November 2024. As an organization we got to know the tremendous work they are doing in Rural parts of Salem & Dharmapuri Districts.



Salem People Trust (SPT) is a non-governmental organization based in Salem, Tamil Nadu, dedicated to promoting social justice and community development, especially among marginalized

and rural populations. Established with the vision of creating inclusive and empowered communities, the organization works across several key areas such as child rights, women's empowerment, education, healthcare, and sustainable livelihoods. Salem People Trust actively engages with local communities, government systems, and partner organizations to implement grassroots-level initiatives that bring long-term impact. Through awareness programs, capacity-building workshops, and direct interventions, the organization aims to uplift vulnerable groups and ensure equitable access to rights and opportunities.

Roles & Responsibilities

The team members of SPT are currently working in 2 major projects. One is “**Analysing the Health and Nutrition of children under 3 years of age in rural parts of Dharmapuri District.**” The other one is “**A study on the nutritional and educational status of children aged 0-18 years in migrant families of selected villages in Dharmapuri District**” My primary role was to assist the community organizers in surveying by gathering details from individual houses in the villages. I was a part of the team that surveyed in the villages Sunkarahalli, Molaiyanoor, & Ettipatty. We covered one entire village in a day and gathered the necessary details

WEEK 1

A detailed discussion of the nutrition Survey held at the office of SPT in Salem, where the program organizers, the community organizers and myself were briefed about the importance the project holds in establishing the nutrition wellness in the rural parts of the district. A detailed questionnaire featuring questions surrounding the nutrition problem was prepared by the staff team.



WEEK 2

The Teams of SPT started to collect data from villages allotted to them. I had been allotted Sukarahalli on day 1, where I had to assist the community organisers in getting data from individual households.

Type of survey:

It was decided by the SPT to conduct a mixed study of both Qualitative & Quantitative data in every village. So, a Questionnaire with a mix of questions was developed by a team of field experts in SPT.

Tools used:

- a. **Questionnaire:** To get the nutrition details of the children
- b. **Weighing machine :** To measure the weight of the children
- c. **Measuring tape:** To note the height of children
- d. **Height and Weight Chart:** To categorise the children into different categories of nutrition levels – SUW (Severely underweight), MUW (Moderately underweight), Normal & Overweight.
- e. **Log book of Anganwadi:** To get the address and contact details of a family.

Village Profile: Sunkarahalli

Surveyed on 14-05-2025

Sunkarahalli is a village located in Pappireddipatti Taluk, Dharmapuri district, Tamil Nadu. It comes under the jurisdiction of Sungarahalli Gram Panchayat in the Kadathur Block. The village is situated approximately 32 km from Dharmapuri. The nearest town for daily economic needs is Kadathur, about 4 km away.

According to the 2011 Census, Sunkarahalli has a total population of 2,064 people living in around 500 households. The sex ratio is approximately 861 females for every 1,000 males. The overall literacy rate of the village is 64.15%, with male literacy at 71.96% and female literacy at 55.08%.



Caste-wise, Scheduled Castes (SC) make up about 46% of the population, while Scheduled Tribes (ST) account for around 2%. The rest of the population belongs to Other Backward Classes.

Agriculture is the main source of livelihood for most villagers. However, due to challenges such as seasonal unemployment, irregular water supply, and limited healthcare services, many young people migrate temporarily to nearby towns and cities for work.

The village has basic facilities like a government upper primary school, ration shop, and access to public and private bus services.

The major issues that the village faces are

- Irregular water supply
- Limited employment opportunities due to which people migrate to nearby towns for work
- Lack of proper healthcare

Methodology:

Before the start of the survey, we gathered the data of children belonging to 3 – 5 years of age from the local Anganwadi. We listed out the address of each house and devised a plan to carry out the survey. Myself, Along with Community organizers **Ms. Karpagam, Ms. Chithra, Ms. Alamelu** from SPT and other Interns **Ms. Saranya** and **Mr. Rahul** carried out the survey, covering the entire village households which had children of the above-mentioned age group. The survey started at 11 am sharp in the morning and was over by 3 pm in the noon.

No. of houses covered:

We got the details of 31 children from the village and surveyed 30 houses.

Limitations:

- Non availability of children in their households due to vacation
- The weather was so humid and hot, with temperatures going to 39°C.
- Non welcoming parents due to negligence and illiteracy.

Findings:

- 16 children belonged to SUW (severely underweight category) and 10 belonged to moderately underweight. Only 5 children were assessed to have normal weight.
- Child marriage among parents (women married during 17 years of age) was identified in 40 % of the households.
- Gap between pregnancies were very low – multiple pregnancies in a short duration, which made it difficult to breastfeed the newborn child.

- 50 % of households had a widened age gap between Father & mother, with former being aged 5 – 7 years older than the latter.

Village profile: Molayanoor

Surveyed on 15-05-

2025

Molayanur is a village located in Pappireddipatti Taluk, Dharmapuri district, Tamil Nadu. It comes under the jurisdiction of Molayanoor Gram Panchayat and falls within the Kadathur Block. The village is situated approximately 40 km from Dharmapuri. The nearest town for daily economic activities, transportation, and essential services is Pappireddipatti.



According to the 2011 Census, Molayanur has a total population of 3,196 people living in around 900 households. The sex ratio is approximately 990 females for every 1,000 males, which is relatively balanced. The overall literacy rate of the village is 65.89%, with male literacy at 74.53% and female literacy at 57.17%.

Caste-wise, Scheduled Castes (SC) make up about 26.5% of the population, while Scheduled Tribes (ST) account for around 9.6%. The remaining population belongs to Other Backward Classes, forming the majority.

Some residents work as daily wage labourers or run small businesses. Due to limited local job opportunities, many young people from the village migrate seasonally to nearby town like Salem & Harur, in search of better income and employment.

The village has basic public facilities including a Government High School, access to bus services, and public water supply. For education beyond high school and for better healthcare, residents depend on facilities in Pappireddipatti or Kadathur

Major issues in the village are

- Lack of local employment leads to seasonal migration
- Limited access to quality healthcare within the village
- Water availability is sometimes irregular in dry seasons
- Infrastructure improvement needed in roads and drainage

Methodology:

Before the start of the survey, we gathered the data of children belonging to 3 – 5 years of age from the local Anganwadi. Myself , with Community organizers Ms. Karpagam, Ms. Chithra, Ms. Alamelu and Intern Mr. Rahul carried out the survey, covering the entire village households which had children of the above-mentioned age group. The survey started at 11:30 am sharp in the morning and was over by 3 pm in the noon.

No. of houses covered:

We got the details of 30 households from the village and surveyed 26 houses.

Limitations:

- Non availability of children in their households due to vacation
- The weather was so humid and hot, with temperatures going to 40°C.
- Non availability of vehicle inside the village for survey
- Sparse location of houses made it difficult to commute.
- Non welcoming parents due to negligence and illiteracy.

Findings:

- 14 children belonged to SUW (severely underweight category) and 7 belonged to moderately underweight.
- Only 5 children were assessed to have normal weight.
- Child marriage among parents (women married during 17 years of age) was identified in 20 % of the households.
- 30 % of the families had widened age gap between mother and the father of the surveyed children.
- 40 % of Parents were unaware of RBSK schemes that exists in Anganwadis.

Young Leadership training – A SPT initiative

As a part of their village development program, SPT organized a special Leadership space for Adolescent women from Poovanur village in Salem District.



Village profile:

Poovanur is a village located in the Ayodhiyapattinam Block of Salem District, Tamil Nadu. It falls under the jurisdiction of the Kuppanoor Gram Panchayat and is situated along the Harur Main Road, providing convenient connectivity to nearby towns. Situated in the foothills of Shevaroy hills, The village is approximately 11 kilometers east of Salem, the district headquarters.

As per the 2011 Census, Poovanur has a population of approximately 1,100 residents.



For higher education, residents often travel to institutions in Salem and surrounding areas.

Healthcare services are accessible in nearby localities, with the closest government health centres located in Achanguttapatti. Nearby towns include Ayodhiyapattinam & Salem.

Theme of the program:

To provide awareness on child marriage and adolescent mental health to women from Under privileged communities.

Event flow:

- The program Co-Ordinator Mr. Gabriel and community organizers of SPT gathered the women students of Poovanur village at a local Anganwadi @ 11:30 am.
- Ms. Alamelu, a local community organizer from SPT facilitated the entire space.
- Key resource persons for the space were Mr. Prabhu from Social welfare dept, Govt of TN, Dr. Subiksha from Achanguddapatti village, a PHC in charge, Ms. Jeya head nurse of Achanguddapatti PHC and Ms. Jeya, the supervisor of the Anganwadi.
- Mr. Gabriel formally introduced the key speakers of the day and formally inaugurated the event.
- **Space 1: Awareness on Cyber security among Adolescent women – Mr Prabhu**
 - a. He spoke on the various laws that govern social security in Tamil Nadu and explained why it is against the law to marry under 18 years of age.
 - b. He also spoke about the adolescent problem of trust and belief over people from internet and neighbourhood.
 - c. He also emphasized the role of family and friends in shaping a better society for women.
 - d. He demonstrated the E – Scan application, a mobile tool that can identify if a mobile is fitted with a bot that steals private data of users. A very technically sound person, he also created awareness about positive use of internet.
- **Space 2: Awareness about Menstrual health and Nutrition – Dr. Subiksha**
 - a. She is a skilled doctor who manages the Achanguddapatti Primary health centre, as a representative of the government of TN.
 - b. She gave a brief speech on how Menstrual health and Mental health are connected to one another.
 - c. She also created awareness on Menstrual hygiene once students leave the village for higher education and job.
 - d. She was joined by the head nurse **Ms. Tamil mani**, who also gave a speech on initiatives of TN government for the welfare of Teenage women and free distribution of Sanitary napkins through the schools.
- **Space 3: Role of Nutrition in shaping a well-built society – Ms. Jeya**
 - a. As a supervisor of the local Anganwadi, she shared her experiences of building a community that was nutritious enough to tackle the day-to-day activities and vowed to help the needy & poor.
- **Conclusion:** Event was concluded by Ms. JAYAM, the managing trustee of SPT by delivering a vote of thanks. She also asked for feedback from the women who attended it.



Mr. Gabriel introducing the speakers



Ms. Alamelu addressing the gathering



Mr. Prabhu creating awareness on Cyber safety



Ms. Jeya speaking on Nutrition



Dr. Subiksha talks about Menstrual Health

WEEK 3

Village Profile: Ettipatti

Surveyed on 19-05-2025

Ettipatty is a village situated in Harur Taluk of Dharmapuri District, Tamil Nadu. It falls under the jurisdiction of the Navalai Gram Panchayat and is part of the Morappur Block. The village is located approximately 44 km east of Dharmapuri and about 6 km from Harur.



As per the 2011 Census, Ettipatty has a total population of 421 individuals residing in around 116 households. The sex ratio stands at approximately 904 females for every 1,000 males, indicating a slightly lower number of females compared to males. The overall literacy rate is 70.55%, with male literacy at 72.40% and female literacy at 68.50%, reflecting a relatively balanced educational attainment between genders.

The residents are engaged in farming and related activities. Due to limited local employment opportunities, some villagers seek seasonal work in nearby towns like Salem & Dharmapuri.

Ettipatty has access to public and private bus services, with the nearest railway station located within a 5–10 km radius.

Educational facilities within the village are limited, prompting students to travel to nearby towns for higher education. Similarly, for healthcare needs, residents often rely on medical facilities in nearby towns.

Methodology

I was accompanying Ms. Usha, a local community organizer from the village for the survey. We carried out the survey, covering the entire village households which had children of the above-mentioned age group. The survey started at 12:15 pm sharp in the morning and was over by 4 pm in the noon.

No. of houses covered:

We got the details of 25 households from the village and surveyed 21 children.

Limitations:

- Non availability of children in their households. Due to vacation, they travelled to nearby villages.
- The weather was so humid and hot, with temperatures going up to 38°C.
- Non availability of certain people due to a recent temple festival; some families travelled to other nearby villages.
- Sparse location of houses made it difficult to commute.
- Non welcoming parents due to negligence and illiteracy.

Findings:

- 5 children belonged to SUW (severely underweight category) and 13 belonged to moderately underweight.
- Only 3 children were assessed to have normal weight.
- Child marriage among parents (women married during 17 years of age) was very negligible in number. (only 2 families)
- 30 % of the families had widened age gap between mother and the father of the surveyed children.
- 30 % of families had close ties between the Mother & father. They were cousins or were married to a very close relative.



WEEK 4

As mentioned earlier, SPT is planning to conduct another study , which focusses on the Migration patterns of selected 15 villages in Dharmapuri district. I was tasked to prepare a draft of a questionnaire that focusses on the Nutrition, health and Financial condition of the families migrated.



With the guidance from Program co Ordinator Mr. Gabriel , we were able to create a first draft of the questionnaire for the Migration study.

Title of the study : **A study on the nutritional and educational status of children aged 0-18 years in migrant families**

It was decided by the Team to conduct surveys among 3 different group of people

- a. Among the families that shifted completely from a village
- b. Among families where only the parent travels, leaving the child back in the village
- c. Among Panchayat presidents, to know the status of migration in their villages
- d. Among young men & women groups, to get their perspectives on Migration

The Questionnaire focussed on Reasons for migration, Nutrition and education focus of the children and impact as a result of migration. Some of the sample questions are

- a. *Who takes care of your children in the village?* *Grandparents / Mother / Relatives*
- b. *Do your children go to Anganwadi?* *Yes / No*
- c. *Do they get pre-primary education & nutritious food from the Anganwadi?* *Yes / No*
- d. *Are you aware of the nutrition status and Primary education of your child?* *Yes / No*
- e. *Do you feel that migration has improved your financial situation?* *Yes / No*
- f. *Did you face any health wise challenge after you migrated to a new place?* *Yes / No*
- g. *If Yes, what is the Issue ? Are you going for a treatment ?* *Yes / No*

Skills Acquired and Learning Experience

It was a great experience to work with SPT in the rural parts of Salem & Dharmapuri districts. I would like to thank team CRY once again for giving me this experience, where I got to witness the ground reality of society and its people in rural Tamil Nadu. Working in Villages gave me a whole lot different perspectives of their Lifestyle, their norms, and the values they try to build in the society. For a person who works in an urban setting, everything he / she sees in the village is a new experience for lifetime and I see this opportunity through the same lens as well.



Some of the skills that I gained through this internship was

- **Surveying** – As a first-time surveyor, I learnt how to look through the data and ask relevant questions that builds purpose on the survey being done fruitfully.
- **Community engagement** – I was able to build conversation with Parents and Children, which made me so connected to them. They started sharing their spaces and thoughts.
- **Data Analysis** – I went through the data I collected which gave a whole new vision about the current reality in Nutrition and health of children. I also got the skills to analyse the trends in different communities and look on a broader lens of the underlying problem and its identification.
- **Question building** – Every other family that I visited had different lives, starting from financial condition to religious identities. Analysing them helped me to build different questions that helped me sail through the surveying phase.
- **Teamwork** – Accompanying a set of Enthusiastic and Excellent community organizers helped me navigate through limitations and hindrances. Their confidence and courage are always an inspiration to me.
- **Group discussion** – When we discussed as a group about the findings of the survey, we were able to build consensus and perspectives that added to strengthen the survey in the next steps.
- **Perspective building & Critical thinking** – through the survey and case studies, I could think critically and build the right perspectives.

- **Questionnaire preparation** – with guidance from SPT team and my previous knowledge about questionnaires, I was able to create a draft for Migration study in villages.

Conclusion

I would like to conclude this report with a summary of overall findings of the Nutrition survey.

S. No.	Village Name	Total Children	Severely Underweight (SUW)	Moderately Underweight (MUW)	Normal
1	Ettipatti	21	5	13	3
2	Soriyampatti	24	10	11	3
3	Veppanatham	23	9	10	4
4	Athiyamankottai (PR)	28	12	14	2
5	Sangilivadi	34	13	16	5
6	Samandahalli	28	13	16	5
7	Elavadai	30	11	9	6
8	Sunkarahalli	31	14	10	7
9	Molayanur	26	16	10	0
10	Pattukonampatti	23	7	10	7
11	Adhagapaadi	23	9	5	9
12	Poonaiyanur	20	9	7	4
	TOTAL →	394	132	204	58

*Highlighted in Green – Team I was a part of Surveying

In terms of percentage,

- Severely Underweight (SUW): 33 %
- Moderately Underweight (MUW): 51 %
- Normal Nutrition Status: 16 %

Among these villages,

- Molayanur reported a concerning pattern, with no child found to be in the normal category; 16 were severely underweight and 10 moderately underweight.

- Villages like Sunkarahalli, Pattukonampatti, and Adhagapaadi showed relatively better outcomes, with a higher number of children in the normal category.

The following are some recommendations from my part:

- Improved awareness among parents about the functioning of Anganwadi Centres (AWCs),
- Access to supplementary nutrition, which is possible in economically better families
- Community-based awareness programs on balanced diets and hygiene.